

On Theoretical and Practical Cognition: Some Remarks

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Religion and science are great powers in the world of spirit. That these ideal [63] powers have often and vehemently made war on one another cannot surprise us when we consider that in origin and essence they are so heterogeneous, and that each of them for itself, when it comes to directing the education and cultivation of the human race, lays claim to hegemony. Religion presupposes a revelation, revelation a miracle; but science denies the miracle, rejects revelation, and thereby comes to offend religion. How ruinous the conflict is, and how beneficial it would be, not only for the life of the congregation but for the life of the people and for the development of culture as a whole, if the misunderstanding—the old misunderstanding which, by setting the two spiritual powers against each other in hostility, has through centuries helped to split and weaken the noblest forces and to confuse the conception of that which is and must be the final goal of all endeavors—could at last be removed, everyone who has seriously thought about the matter will surely grant.

Should it now really be possible that a misunderstanding so deeply ingrown as that between faith and knowledge, religion and science, could ever be removed from [64] the ground up?

It seems almost impossible, when one properly considers how much is required here for a good understanding. For a good understanding between faith and knowledge it is not enough, namely, that the parties at last bring themselves to tolerate each other, so that some in society are allowed to cultivate science without troubling themselves about the life of faith, while the great majority, without insight into the

laws of nature and of science, ingenuously accepts whatever theologians and priests, as time and occasion suggest, find it serviceable to explain to the faithful about the miracles of faith.

Such an agreement brings with it only a characterless intermediate state. But a characterless intermediate state has something sadly dulling for the life of spirit; the salutary thing is that under an armed neutrality a spark can smolder which, before one knows it, bursts into flame.

A good understanding between religion and science requires that the two powers be able essentially to acknowledge each other and, in mutual acknowledgment, agree to work together toward one and the same highest goal. But for this to happen, the two principles, faith and knowledge, must allow themselves to be *united in one consciousness*. The believer must then, without harm to his faith, be able to become a knower, and the knower, without denying or halving his knowledge, be a believer; for the all-round cultivated person it must, in other words, be possible to give to faith what is faith's, and to knowledge what is knowledge's.

Once the demand is plainly, freely and openly stated, the objections will press forward with spiritual natural necessity. "Should the absolutely heterogeneous principles of faith and knowledge really allow themselves to be united in one consciousness, then the same person must indeed accept as believing what he as knowing denies, the miracle of revelation; he must therefore at one and the same time both acknowledge and not acknowledge the very same thing; but that is an intolerable contradiction. [65] Whoever, despite the contradiction, would attempt to solve such a task must then begin by halving his consciousness. Just as that king who smiled with half his face and threatened with the other half showed himself, in a certain sense, as a man with two faces, so the consciousness that was to unite the two heterogeneous principles would have to be knowing with the one half and believing with the other, have one truth in the one and another in the other, and so show itself with two truths (*duæ veritates*). And what good would that do? So long as the two truths are united in one consciousness only in such a way that they are kept apart, each in its own room, by a kind of intellectual partition wall, the opposition that earlier aroused strife and discord in the outward has merely been moved into the inward. If the partition wall bursts—and burst it surely must, once the spirit shakes off the mechanical—then there is danger that the heterogeneous truths, as they are united, will fuse together in an explosion that shatters understanding and brain."

By thus laying bare the supposed contradiction, we have managed to see the

problem come into being. But that a problem must come into being is indeed the first condition for its being solvable. Can it, then, be solved? It calls for an attempt.

The “great, gruesome, terrible contradiction” that people have wished to find in the circumstance that consciousness, by acknowledging two absolutely heterogeneous principles, would split itself in such a way that it lost its unity and with it its energy, does not, when we look more closely, amount to much. Anyone who has practiced enough dialectic to have learned to see what it is that essentially matters in the relation between an absolute and a relative will without difficulty convince himself that principles which are absolutely heterogeneous may very well stand in mutual relation and in this relation show themselves relative. Anyone who has acquired enough psychology to know the first basic features of the doctrine of the unity of consciousness through its pervasive self-duplications will, on some reflection, be able to tell himself that in the life of spirit there are oppositions—deep, strong oppositions bordering on dualism—which are nevertheless so far from weakening the unity of self-consciousness that they on the contrary heighten and confirm it. [66]

Among the commonest and therefore best-known forms of duplication of the life of spirit is without doubt the opposition between theory and practice, between theoretical and practical cognition.

That theory and practice must be able to stand in relation, indeed in essential relation, to each other, no one will surely deny; but notwithstanding this they each have their own principle and are to that extent heterogeneous. If a theoretical grounding may not mix in practical considerations, then neither can actual practice simply be derived from theory. Were someone to ask: which is the original in the life of consciousness, theoretical or practical cognition?—who would then hesitate over an answer?

How pervasive the opposition between theoretical and practical cognition is can best be seen from the corresponding transformation of consciousness. The theoretical consciousness is impersonal, the practical is personal; the former is contemplative, disinterested, lost without self-regard in the universal, moved by necessity, forgetting itself in the grounding of the objective; the latter, by contrast, is interested, in conflict with existence, moved by fear and hope, desire and expectation, full of self-regard even in its self-denial. The theoretical consciousness is essentially *thinking*, the practical essentially *willing*.

That will is required to develop thought, and thought to apply the will, is understandable; thought and will, the theoretical and practical factors of consciousness,

certainly stand in mutual relation and are, in their difference, to that extent relative; [67] but thought is not for that reason will, nor will thought; theory is not practice, nor practice theory: the theoretical consciousness, which gives itself up to thoughts and thinking, lives in another region than the practical, which concentrates itself in resolve and will.

It is a misunderstanding—a misunderstanding deadly to religion, morality and all higher development of character—to make the will a modification of thinking, a misunderstanding which, as far as modern philosophy is concerned, can be said to begin with Spinoza (*voluntas et intellectus unum et idem sunt*), to be completed by Hegel. In the Hegelian philosophy it is *das Denken und das Denken und das allgemeine Denken* on which everything, first and last, depends. From this standpoint J. L. Heiberg too, in his “Introductory Lecture to the Logic Course,”^{*)} has set forth with consistency and clarity the relation between the theoretical and the practical, the logical and the ethical. “Only the cultivation of thinking,” he says, “is the cultivation of the human being, for thought is at once the *human*, which separates us from subordinate nature, and the *divine*, which unites us with the world above us. Perhaps it will be objected that the same can be said of *feeling*; so it can, but only insofar as feeling is permeated by thought. Faith, love, honor, duty are certainly feelings which separate us from nature and incorporate us into a higher world; but what gives these feelings so great a value are the thought-determinations contained in them, without which they could not exist in the form of feelings. If, for example, there were not a moral world in which good and evil were separated according to the rational determinations of thought, then neither could we separate them in our feeling; we would then have no moral [68] feeling or feeling of duty, no love of the good and no abhorrence of evil, for all these feelings presuppose a power that determines them; this power is thought, which is the sole absolute ground of determination. . . If it stands firm, then, that thought is both the human and the divine in us, then it is equally certain that the cultivation of our thinking is the cultivation of ourselves.” When thinking is in this way made one with the human being, so that the distinctive essence of the human being becomes only a modification of universal, objective thinking, then it follows of itself that the will, despite its subjective essence, must also be a modification of objective thought.

But who does not see that such views must lead us onto extremely dangerous byways? As opium acts as a narcotic on the nerves, so objective thinking, when it is to be applied according to the above theory, acts as a narcotic on the practical

^{*)}*Prosaiske Skrifter*, vol. I, p. 465.

consciousness; and just as the enjoyment of opium can at first replace the lost reality with indescribable raptures and paradisaal dream-visions but, when the dream is over, leaves terrible effects behind, so too a deification of theory's objective thinking can at first enrapture the beholder who sees the ideals of existence in the mirror; but when the contemplation is at an end, actuality stands only all the more angular, hard and defiant against the right of ideality; it is then in vain that thinking tries to explain away a reality it cannot bear.

In relation to actuality and the tasks of actual life, practical cognition must absolutely have greater originality than theoretical. The will, to be sure, in order to be will, must originally presuppose thought; but, mark well, it is in the first place not theoretical but practical thinking that the will presupposes, and in the second place the will, with this presupposing of its own, is just as original as thought. Just as in thought there is something that cannot be derived from the will, since thought as [69] thought is not will, so too in the will there is something that cannot be derived from thought, since will as will is not thought. Certainly such categories as freedom of choice, choice, resolution, etc., fall under the illumination of thought insofar as they become clear in moral cognition; but in principle they are nonetheless categories of the will; their cognition is essentially practical. What is cognized theoretically cannot be cognized practically; it is no use appealing to the fact that the content cognized is the same, only the mode of cognition different: in every decisive cognition the content is determined by the mode, and the mode by the content. That courage as a virtue can be cognized in theory must be granted; but if the courage that is cognized theoretically were really in each and every respect the same, the very same, as that which is cognized practically, what would then follow? It would indeed follow that an able theoretical thinker, without venturing anything, without exposing his life to any real danger, could think himself so far into true courage that in reality he thereby thought true courage into himself, and thus, by objective thinking, however cowardly he might otherwise be by nature, actually became courageous. But that he who is in reality cowardly, however theoretically he may think, can no more speculate himself into real courage than he who is without money, even if he were to think theoretically-objectively until he burst, can speculate himself into real money, needs no proof.

How deep the chasm is which, because of the heterogeneous principles, forms the separation between theoretical and practical cognition can further be seen from the fact that absolute truth itself must divide into two truths, an impersonal one, which

corresponds one-sidedly to thinking, and a personal one, which corresponds to the will. That the idea of thinking is specially named truth, while the idea of the will, according to a commonly accepted usage, is named the good, has in recent times not [70] been sufficient to avert the theoretical encroachment by which the two ideas have been fused together in such a way that the good has perished in the true, just as the will has in thinking. Theory does indeed posit a difference between thought and will, between the true and the good; but since the difference itself falls within theory, and consequently is and remains theoretical, thinking naturally keeps the upper hand throughout.

Every time the question is raised of the validity of the presuppositions either of ethics or of religion, one notices the presumption of theory. Freedom of choice, for example, cannot have unconditional validity; and why not? Because objective thinking, when it is to comprehend freedom, can do nothing other than reduce arbitrariness to a moment subordinate to the preponderant motives, so that freedom is transformed into a necessity transparent in reflection. But the reality of the will surely demands an unconditional self-determination; the idea of the good demands an original freedom, valid in and through itself. Yes, answers theory, let the will as factual arbitrariness make as merry as it likes, let the idea of the good in practice pitch its demands as high as it likes: when the question concerns the reality of the will and of the good, then it is a matter of truth; and when it is a matter of truth, then it is after all thinking—universally valid thinking, developing itself in knowledge—that is and remains the supreme judge. If it is the God of revelation, the almighty Creator of heaven and earth, that is under discussion, theory knows at once that the “almighty Creator” of the article of faith cannot possibly be the true God; and why not? Because the act of creation cannot possibly be thought as an act of arbitrariness, and so not, as the article nevertheless evidently presupposes, as an unconditional act of freedom! But religion, revealed religion, which proclaims itself as the absolute good, simply cannot subsist without such a presupposition; God himself would indeed cease to [71] be the Holy One, the truly Almighty, if in his relation to the world he were not the absolutely free God, the God who creates out of nothing. Religion here, religion there! what good does it do, says theory, to appeal either to the immediate authority of a revealed word or to the popular representations of religion, when the question concerns an eternal truth. Only for objective thought is truth objective; a god may be as holy as he likes in the popular imagination; if he is not the God of the concept, then neither is he a true God; if he is not a true God, then his holiness means nothing.

Against such a despotism of knowledge a protest must be made. To protest against the despotism of theories is by no means—as has sometimes been alleged from an abstract theoretical standpoint—the same as violating, or at least veiling, the rich truth; on the contrary, it is high time, not only in the name of religion and ethics but in the name of truth, indeed in the name of theory itself, that objections be raised against the undue encroachment of objective knowledge, of theoretical cognition.

The protest with which practical cognition repels the encroachment of theory is not the desperate attempt of an intellectual tendency which, for lack of objective grounds, would resort to a peremptory decree, incite arbitrariness and appeal to a blind subjectivity. Practical cognition is in this case so far from doing violence to theoretical cognition that it begins, on the contrary, with freedom, the original freedom which theory itself, when it properly comes to theoretical reflection, must grant to subjectivity. For what is most subjective in subjectivity is after all the self; but the selfhood of the self is self-determining, is will. If theoretical cognition now finds itself compelled to grant will and freedom the same originality it grants to thinking and reflection, then it also finds itself compelled to grant the subjective, [72] personal truth—the idea of the will, of the good—the same originality it grants to the idea of thinking, the impersonal, objective truth. “And what more,” asks the theorist, “can practical cognition then demand?” It can demand, we answer, that theory take its own concessions seriously; it can demand that the practical idea, in everything practical, be just as autonomous, and hence just as independent of irrelevant theories, as the theoretical idea, in everything that exclusively concerns the theoretical, must be exempt from the disturbing interference of practical interests; it can demand that the principle of the will be respected; it can demand that the coin of freedom—in spite of objective, even dogmatic-objective, speculations—be converted from theory’s nominal value into the currency of character, into the silver value of existence.

On these conditions, but also only on these, can a true understanding be brought about between theory and practice. Once this understanding has been brought about, not superficially but from the ground up, a reconciliation of faith and knowledge, religion and science, will follow as of itself; for religion is practical from first to last, science theoretical from first to last: faith is an ideal of the will, knowledge an ideal of thought.

It goes without saying that the ideals of thought and will must be able to enter into just as many-sided an interrelation as thought and will themselves; every attempt to draw a definitively fixed boundary line that would separate theoretical cognition from

practical is to that extent unreasonable and meaningless. But there is here nonetheless a boundary, a difference in principle, which arises from the fact that in theory all the powers of the soul are subordinated to thinking, whereas in practice they are subordinated to the will.

Of every idea of life, to be sure, there can be both a theoretical and a practical cognition; but how pervasive the difference is becomes evident at a glance at the idea of God. It is necessary to say it resolutely: the God of thought, whose cognition is theoretical, cannot be the God of faith, for of the God of faith there is only a practical cognition. The opposition between faith and knowledge, religion and science, practical and theoretical cognition, cannot be expressed more strongly than when it is expressly said that they each have their own God. [73]

“And this,” one asks, “is supposed to be the good understanding?” We answer: Yes, it is the best understanding that can be conceived. When science fully sees that it can no more cognize the God of faith than religion can cognize the God of knowledge, while religion, from the standpoint of its practical cognition, sees the same thing—what then? “Why, then,” one exclaims, “they must for the first time come into serious conflict with each other, for each of them will naturally take its God to be not merely a true God but the only true God!” Such effusions, which, as far as theory is concerned, characterize lively rather than thorough heads, are evidently based on superficial reasoning.

When it is said that faith and knowledge cannot possibly have the same God, the meaning is naturally not that the God of faith is another than the God of knowledge in the same sense as the Emperor of China is another than the Emperor of Brazil; the meaning is rather that the divine which is thought is not an object of faith, and that God, insofar as he is an object of faith, is not, and by the nature of the case cannot be, an object for comprehending thought.

That the science of spirit, insofar as it understands itself, must be willing to enter into the proposed separation is natural; for no philosophy has yet developed the concept of God in such a way that the God cognized in the concept could become an object of faith. Whoever claims that anyone can really believe either in Aristotle’s God or in Leibnitz’s God or in Hegel’s God is thoughtless and does not know what he is saying. But that religion, for its part, cannot have anything against the separation either likewise lies in the nature of the case, and is unequivocally granted by the Apostle Paul. [74]

When Paul (Rom. 1, 19–22) speaks of what is distinctive in the heathens’ cognition

of God, he evidently lays weight on that in God's being which can be thought, on "that which may be known of God" (τὸ γνωστὸν τοῦ θεοῦ), on God's "invisible being, his eternal power and Godhead" (ἡ τε αἰδὶος αὐτοῦ δύναμις καὶ θεϊότης), "which are beheld and understood" (νοούμενα καθορᾶται) from his works. It is therefore, in the stricter sense, not the God of the will but the God of thought that has made himself known to the heathens. It is the Godhead revealed in the realm of nature, the Godhead of essentiality, of ground, of power, of laws and of rational necessity, whose intellectual light has been able to shine for the peoples of nature. But that a cognition of God which on these conditions must become more theoretical than practical, and so aim more at essence than at will, can furnish only a weak foundation for the ethical—that the theory of God has not been able to secure the principles of moral life—the following verses (22–32) make evident in so penetrating a manner that the picture they sketch of corruption must horrify us.

How different the heathen cognition of God is from the Jewish and the Christian can be seen from the ninth chapter of the Epistle to the Romans. For what kind of God is it, after all, of whom Paul speaks in this chapter? It is not the God of thought, whose freedom dawns in an overarching necessity; no, it is the God of freedom, whose essence is unconditional will. The God "revealed" to the heathens has, to be sure, a will too, but it is only a thought-will, a will that is a moment of the good identical with objective truth (*Deus vult, quia bonum est*). The God of Israel, by contrast, is sheer will, his thoughts will-thoughts, his conclusions decrees, his elections pure arbitrariness. For that the God of revelation is represented as the God of arbitrariness by no means implies that God's unconditional will should play games either with necessity or with truth or with goodness; on the contrary! All ground, all truth and goodness has precisely (Rom. 11, 32–33) its center, its point of departure and its point of rest in the divine will (*bonum est, quia Deus vult*). [75]

How impossible it is to develop any objective theory of the God of the will, anyone who will look into the Epistle to the Romans can, on some reflection, tell himself; and should he feel the need of further proof, then the theological quackeries of scriptural interpretation, the speculative self-contradictions of dogmatics and the abracadabra of the theories of predestination will supply proofs in abundance. But the same thing that makes it impossible for the God of arbitrariness to be an object of theoretical cognition, that very same thing also makes the revealed God of the will be, and necessarily be, an object of faith. As object of faith the God of the will is originally the God of miracle; for what is miracle but the unconditional power of the divine

will over all conditions? He who stakes his life on a general thinking perhaps gets a theory about life, but is cheated of life itself; he who sets his mind on the practical cognition of a holy will perhaps misses the theory, but he gains life, the eternal life of spirit, for the life of spirit is in the will.

How inwardly faith and practical cognition are bound up with the will can be seen in obedience. To believe in God is to obey God, is to do God's will; but to obey God is in turn the same as to believe in God, for the first commandment of the will is faith. How inwardly faith and obedience correspond to each other can be seen in the two most eminent phenomena of religious cognition that our age has to show, Grundtvig and S. Kierkegaard: *faith is essentially obedience*—this is, in brief, [76] Kierkegaard's explanation; *obedience is essentially faith, faith in the Word of life that is the light of men*—this is, in sum, Grundtvig's explanation. The two explanations are so far from standing in mutual conflict that they rather complete, illuminate and confirm one another.

Should it still really be, as some claim, impossible for one and the same consciousness to acknowledge both the practical and the theoretical, both faith and knowledge, then it would in any case be the theoretical, not the practical, that would have to be given up. Existence is practical; a consciousness can exist without being theoretical; but a consciousness cannot be theoretical without existing. It is therefore possible to put existence uppermost and keep theory; but to derive existence from theory, to put theory uppermost and keep existence, is impossible. The ideal of existence is will, for existence is practical; the ideal of thought is knowledge, for thought, objective thought, is theoretical: to put the ideal of existence uppermost and keep the ideal of thought is possible, but to put the ideal of thought uppermost and satisfy the ideal of existence is impossible; in other words: to put faith uppermost and keep science is possible; but to put science uppermost and keep faith is impossible.

Should anyone, however, be so lively in the head and so light in his thoughts that his head really spins, so that he cannot make out what is to stand uppermost and what lowermost, faith or knowledge, but out of sheer liveliness confuses uppermost with lowermost and lowermost with uppermost, let him try to simplify matters by throwing away faith, the ideal of the will, the principle of character, and living on pure theory: he still does not escape the duplication. The duplication of theoretical and practical is then placed within theory. To preserve the unity of self-consciousness, a person would then have to have his theory in the practical, his practice in the [77] theoretical, his thinking in his willing and his willing in his thinking; but no lively

person will surely boast of having solved the riddle of existence by solving such a task. By duplicating oneself practically within the theoretical, one becomes, with all possible liveliness, in lively duplication—not an ethical character, but an intellectual amphibian.
